

Setting the tab

With rising power costs, it's time to take a look at ways we can reduce our electricity consumption. To reduce your PC's power consumption, it's important to get the right hardware in place and tweak your settings according to your needs. Before you know it, your laptop battery will be going longer than usual and your electricity bill will see a substantial cut.

Hardware

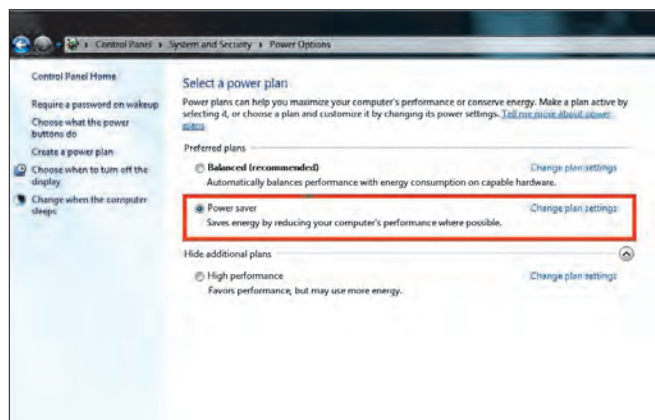
First make sure your power socket and wiring is good. You can ask an electrician to verify this. If either of these is faulty, your computer can try to sap more electricity than it needs.

Solid state drives and ultra-low voltage processors are becoming increasingly affordable and offer significant boosts in power usage. When

cient technology for screens, while LCD comes second. An LCD monitor can reduce your power consumption by 70 per cent when compared with a CRT monitor.

Reducing the brightness of the screen also reduces power consumption. Change your monitor's settings and reduce the brightness to a point where it's still comfortable to read text easily. A simple way is to open a Word document, set the font to Arial, size 8. Change the colour to a grey that is mid way between white and black on the font colour palette. Now reduce your screen brightness or contrast to the point where this text is legible. With this setting, all other text you come across should be easily readable for you.

Unplug any external devices you won't be using, such as portable hard drives,



Power saver mode in Windows is your first step in cutting down

any disc in it. Each disc periodically asks the computer to seek it, thus taking up more power.

Software

If you're running Windows 7, there's good news for you as Microsoft has come up with a special **Power Saver** mode which will ensure your computer does not take up any more electricity than needed. To activate this, go to **Control Panel > System and Security >**

on Change plan settings. The two main options here are the amount of time in which the computer will automatically switch off the monitor and the amount of time it will put the computer to sleep. Tweak it to your heart's content – we recommend keeping the display turn-off at 5 minutes and the computer sleep time at 10 minutes.

Not many people know that the screensaver actually guzzles up a lot of power. You can program your PC to automatically turn off the display through Power Options. Install MonitorOff (www.monitor-off.com) that lets you configure hotkeys and different timers and other schedules for your monitor to be automatically switched off when not in use.

If the above settings are already enabled, and you wish to have more control over your computer's power usage, a nifty free application called SetPower (<http://www.setpowersoftware.com/Free.aspx>) might just be the answer. Immensely customisable and robust, SetPower lets you create power profiles and schedules for your computer based on hourly, daily and monthly requirements.



LCD or CRT?

choosing a monitor, go for an LED monitor over an LCD, and an LCD monitor over a CRT. LED is the most power-effi-

cient technology for screens, while LCD comes second. An LCD monitor can reduce your power consumption by 70 per cent when compared with a CRT monitor. Reducing the brightness of the screen also reduces power consumption. Change your monitor's settings and reduce the brightness to a point where it's still comfortable to read text easily. A simple way is to open a Word document, set the font to Arial, size 8. Change the colour to a grey that is mid way between white and black on the font colour palette. Now reduce your screen brightness or contrast to the point where this text is legible. With this setting, all other text you come across should be easily readable for you. Unplug any external devices you won't be using, such as portable hard drives,

Power Options and select the **Power Saver** power plan.

You can further customise your power plan by clicking